tasted by the cooks as well as the mir bakawal (master of the kitchen) after which the dishes were wrapped in cloth, sealed, and tagged with the name of the contents; then an inventory of all the dishes was drawn up. Once all the dishes were sealed, mace bearers led a procession of male servants bearing the food, keeping all onlookers away. The dishes were then transferred to eunuchs, who carried the food part of the way before handing it over to young girls who brought the dishes into the presence of the Padshah. In the dining area, tentatively identified by historian Rezavi as the building erroneously called ‘Maryam’s house’ over the ages, a crisp white cloth was laid on the ground and the dishes were unsealed and tasted a second time. The mir bakawal and the table servants remained in attendance on the emperor as he ate his meal which, in addition to the many dishes cooked, was accompanied by breads including hot chapattis, fresh ginger, limes, various greens, and fresh yoghurt. At the end of the meal, Akbar prostrated himself for a prayer of thanks.

And everywhere in Fatehpur Sikri, in ever greater numbers, were the animals. The elephants, horses, and camels in their stables but also the pigeons in their dovecotes, the companionable dogs, the noiseless cheetahs roaming free through the courtyards at dusk, and the silent, ferocious hawks.

For all these various activities, for the women in their seclusion, the children at their studies, the kitchen, stables, armoury, and soon, religious discussions, Akbar built in the arid landscape a glowing city of dreams.